Democratic Rights and State Power

GS II

- The Constitution protects citizens' **freedom to express opinions**, assemble peacefully and participate in public protests. These rights allow people to question government decisions and demand accountability. Restrictions must have a lawful basis and cannot be imposed merely because criticism makes authorities uncomfortable.

- Police may regulate demonstrations to maintain public order, but their actions must remain **lawful and proportionate**. Detaining peaceful protesters, restricting movement or using excessive force without adequate justification can turn public-order measures into violations of fundamental rights.

- Independent institutions strengthen democracy by examining whether government actions follow constitutional rules. When allegations of electoral irregularities or misuse of police powers arise, **transparent investigations** and credible institutional responses become essential for maintaining public confidence in democratic processes.

- Courts protect constitutional freedoms by reviewing executive actions and providing remedies against unlawful restrictions. However, **judicial intervention** becomes meaningful only when authorities respect legal safeguards and implement decisions. Otherwise, repeated restrictions can weaken citizens' ability to exercise their rights.

Peaceful dissent is an essential democratic safeguard. Public order must be maintained through lawful, proportionate measures that respect fundamental rights and institutional accountability.